“He’s had nine years. It’s enough. If you have no ideas, it’s time to step aside.”

Herzog did have economic ideas, which called for billions of dollars of additional spending and an expanded role for government. On the deeper issues, though, he spoke only in generalities, largely ignoring the Palestinians, offering no plan for Gaza. He seemed like a vestige of an older Israel, when the political consensus was both more settled and more liberal. Had he won, he would have taken over a country that has moved sharply to the right, and one that fractured during Netanyahu’s tenure. He would have ushered in a rhetorical change, a sense of normalcy—but little more.

“All parts of our society are simmering from within,” he said at one campaign event during his closing argument. “My role as a leader is to unite everybody… if I’m strong enough, I’ll be able to lower everyone’s prices, and move toward a coalition that will move Israel in the right direction. And that’s all I can say.”

The tribes of Israel

The outcome was seen in the West as further evidence of Israel’s drift to the right. “We’ve also seen reports from Israel describing it as the most right-wing coalition in Israel’s history,” said Mark Toner, the State Department spokesman, at a press briefing in late May, after Netanyahu cobbled together his coalition. “And we also know that many of its ministers have said they opposed a two-state solution. This raises legitimate questions about the direction it may be headed in.”

Over the seven-decade sweep of Israel’s political history, it is fair to say the country as a whole has become more conservative. The first half of that history was dominated entirely by the center-left predecessors of the Labor party. Likud didn’t win its first election until 1977. Since then, however, the left has struggled to regain power: right-wing prime ministers have ruled for twenty-nine of the past forty years.

Yet by the same count, those electoral results also suggest that the right-wing camp has hit a ceiling. In 1981, the right/religious bloc won 64 seats; the Zionist left/center-left won 52; and Hadash, a Jewish-Palestinian Communist party, won 4. Fast forward to 2015: voters gave 67 seats to the right/religious bloc; 40 to the left/center-left; and 13 to the Palestinians. The left ceded a lot of ground—but largely to the Arab parties, which came into